think of other matters. That crisis again is accentuated by the

ever-present crisis of want of confidence in the Government's

ability and bona fides.*

** The Famine Inquiry Commission, presided over by Sir John Woodhead (Report published*

in May, 19f 5), reveal in restrained official language the tragic succession of official errors and private greed which led to the Bengal famine. 'It has been for us a sad task,' they say,

'to inquire into the course and causes of the Bengal famine. We have been haunted by a deep sense of tragedy. A million and a half of the poor of Bengal fell victims to circumstances for which they themselves were not responsible. Society, together with its organs, failed to protect its weaker members. Indeed there was a moral and social breakdown, as well as administrative breakdowns.' They refer to the low economic level of the province, to the increasing

pressure on land not relieved by growth of industry, to the fact that a considerable section of the population was living on the margin of subsistence and was uncapable of standing any

severe economic stress, to the very bad health conditions and low standards of nutrition, to the absence of a 'margin of safety' as regards either health or wealth. They consider the

more immediate causes to be: the failure of the season's crop, the fall of Burma leading to stoppage of imports of Burma rice, to the 'denial' policy of Government which brought ruin

to certain poorer classes, to the military demands on food and transport, and the lack of

confidence in the Government. They condemn the policy, or often the lack of policy or the